

Broken Archive Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 35-45 min

Category	History	Time	35-45 min
Difficulty	Extended	ID	broken-archive

Big idea: The past survives as incomplete traces.

Overview

Students reconstruct a past event from incomplete and biased sources.

Student Prompt

Inspect Broken Archive Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Broken Archive Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A partial archive with missing letters, dates, or voices. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Broken Archive Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Students reconstruct an event from incomplete evidence cards. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Broken Archive Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A source silence note asking who is absent and why. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — The past survives as incomplete traces.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Broken Archive Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Broken Archive Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Can we know the past if we cannot observe it directly?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how the past survives as incomplete traces.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A partial archive with missing letters, dates, or voices.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A partial archive with missing letters, dates, or voices.
- Students reconstruct an event from incomplete evidence cards.
- A source silence note asking who is absent and why.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Give each group a different combination of sources.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Groups reconstruct what happened.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Groups compare narratives and identify what evidence they lacked.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	The class ranks which sources were most useful and most dangerous.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat sources as transparent windows rather than selected traces.
- Students may confuse explaining context with excusing actions.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Uses source evidence while naming selection, silence, and perspective.
- Distinguishes historical claim, interpretation, and judgement.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Same Event, Different Historian
- Cause Web
- Presentism Trial